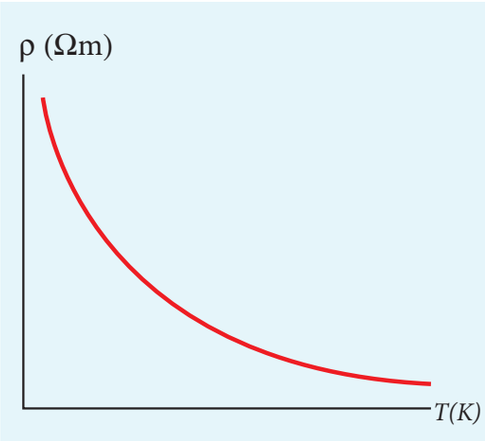


Figure 2.14 Temperature dependence of resistivity for a semiconductor

Hence the current increases and therefore the resistivity decreases as shown in Figure 2.14. A semiconductor with a negative temperature coefficient of resistivity is called a thermistor.

The typical values of temperature coefficients of various materials are given in table 2.3.

Table 2.3

Material	Temperature Coefficient of resistivity α [(°C)$^{-1}$]
Silver	3.8×10^{-3}
Copper	3.9×10^{-3}
Gold	3.4×10^{-3}
Aluminum	3.9×10^{-3}
Tungsten	4.5×10^{-3}
Iron	5.0×10^{-3}
Platinum	3.92×10^{-3}
Lead	3.9×10^{-3}
Nichrome	0.4×10^{-3}
Carbon	-0.5×10^{-3}
Germanium	-48×10^{-3}
Silicon	-75×10^{-3}

We can understand the temperature dependence of resistivity in the following way. In section 2.1.3, we have shown that the electrical conductivity, $\sigma = \frac{ne^2\tau}{m}$. As the resistivity is inverse of σ, it can be written as

$$\rho = \frac{m}{ne^2\tau} \qquad (2.30)$$

The resistivity of materials is

i) inversely proportional to the number density (n) of the electrons

ii) inversely proportional to the average time between the collisions (τ).

In metals, if the temperature increases, the average time between the collision (τ) decreases and n is independent of temperature. In semiconductors when temperature increases, n increases and τ decreases, but increase in n is dominant than decreasing τ, so that overall resistivity decreases.



The resistance of certain materials become zero below certain temperature T_c. This temperature is known as critical temperature or transition temperature. The materials which exhibit this property are known as superconductors. This phenomenon was first observed by Kammerlingh Onnes in 1911. He found that mercury exhibits superconductor behaviour at 4.2 K. Since R = 0, current once induced in a superconductor persists without any potential difference.

EXAMPLE 2.13

If the resistance of coil is 3 Ω at 20^0 C and α = 0.004/^{0}C then determine its resistance at 100 ^{0}C.

UNIT-2(XII-Physics_Vol-1).indd 96 14-02-2020 19:37:04